importance of doing things without waiting for the government to do it for you. I pointed out that when individuals or private groups were involved in helping the needy, none of the contributions were spent on overhead or administrative costs, unlike government relief programs where $2 was often spent on overhead for every $1 that went to needy people.

When I sat down, my remarks got a huge ovation. As we were driving away from the plant, the man from GE said, “I didn’t know you could give speeches.” I said, “I have been doing that for quite a while.”

Well, that changed everything. From then on, whenever I went to a GE plant, in addition to meeting workers, they’d schedule a speech or two for me to a local organization like the United Fund or Chamber of Commerce; before long, the company began to get requests for me to speak before larger audiences—state conventions of service organizations and groups like the Executives Club in Chicago and the Commonwealth Club in San Francisco.

For eight years I hopscotched around the country by train and automobile for GE and visited every one of its 139 plants, some of them several times. Along the way, I met more than 250,000 employees of GE—not just shaking their hands, but talking to them and listening to what was on their minds.

Looking back now, I realize it wasn’t a bad apprenticeship for someone who’d someday enter public life—although, believe me, that was the farthest thing from my mind in those days.

As a radio sports announcer, I had sometimes flown to ball games or other events I was covering in an open-cockpit biplane wearing a leather helmet and goggles, and I’d loved it. But during the early fifties, there was an epidemic of plane crashes that caused something inside me to say it wasn’t a safe time for me to go flying. Call it a hunch if you